countries. Such a stance is only rhetorical, however, as Bangladesh lacks the leverage to give its remarks substance. Solutions will depend on the kind of relationship India decides it wants with its smaller and weaker neighbour and on the diplomatic skill [that] Bangladesh can muster in negotiating from a position of weakness. While Bangladesh's delicate political condition reduces its ability to resist external pressures, any sign of subservience to India on important issues would imperil the survival of any government in Dhaka.

On the diplomatic level, India acted as a large-hearted neighbour and tried to salvage the situation by opening communication lines with Dhaka. Ershad had invited External Affairs Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao to Dhaka months after declaring the martial law. Rao landed at Dhaka airport on 22 May 1982 and formal discussions were held on regional and international issues.

In October 1982, Ershad arrived in New Delhi. His visit was seen as a serious attempt to solidify the relationship between the two countries in the political, economic and cultural spheres. Indira Gandhi and Ershad agreed to set up a joint economic commission to increase commercial exchange with Dhaka. India signed an agreement on sharing the waters of the River Teesta with Bangladesh, but other critical issues like the augmentation of the Ganga waters at Farakka and large-scale infiltration from Bangladesh remained major worries.

According to documents in the MEA, Ershad told Indira, 'We must be friends—I mean, good friends. Our relations should be based on goodwill and neighbourliness, on large-heartedness and understanding, free from pre-independence and inherited